The protests cannot be brushed aside. They are a warning from a generation that has invested heavily in education but is increasingly uncertain about its returns. Yet they should not become the only lens through which to view Indian higher education. Alongside the failures are institutions that are expanding access, redesigning curricula, producing high-quality research, improving clinical and professional training, incubating enterprises and creating more inclusive campuses.

A ranking published in a year of student protest must ask more than which university appears on top. It must examine what academic leadership looks like, whether institutions are keeping pace with economic and technological change, how effectively they support students, and whether the education they provide leads to intellectual growth, professional capability and meaningful opportunity. For students and parents, its value lies in helping them ask better questions before making one of the most consequential and expensive decisions of their lives.

INDIA'S MOST IMPROVED UNIVERSITIES

CATEGORY	MOST IMPROVED UNIVERSITY
GENERAL GOVERNMENT	UNIVERSITY OF LUCKNOW, LUCKNOW
GENERAL PRIVATE	SATHYABAMA INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE AND TECHNOLOGY (DEEMED TO BE UNIVERSITY)
MEDICAL	N.A.
TECHNICAL	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY KHARAGPUR
LAW	DAMODARAM SANJIVAYYA NATIONAL LAW UNIVERSITY, VISAKHAPATNAM

The Most Improved Universities are ranked based on their percentage growth in ranking over the past five years (2022–2026) in the India Today–MDRA Best Universities Ranking

The challenge is to distinguish those responding to a changing world from those merely adding courses, buildings and credentials.

It is in this complex backdrop that the India Today Group publishes the 2026 edition of its annual Best Universities Survey. It does not intend to just applaud institutions that already enjoy reputational advantages or to reduce a vast, varied university system to a league table. It is another way of holding up a mirror to the state of higher education by celebrating the best, identifying what they are doing differently and encouraging the rest to improve through a healthy competitive environment.

The need for such scrutiny has grown with the extraordinary expansion of Indian higher education. The country now has 1,293 universities, more than double the number in 2014-15. This represents a remarkable democratisation of aspiration. A university degree is no longer the preserve of a small urban elite. Families across classes, regions and social groups increasingly see higher education as the most credible route to employment, mobility and dignity.

The rise of private universities has widened choice and introduced new programmes, facilities and

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